Protecting Consumers and Promoting Modern Networks – Technology Transitions

Today's communications marketplace offers consumers and businesses a vast array of advanced services that better meet their needs, compared to the legacy voice service that first connected Americans in the 19th century.

With these advanced services come several benefits, such as better protections against robocalls, next-generation 911 services, enhanced network reliability, and access to telehealth services.

Recognizing these benefits, the majority of households are now wireless-only or wireless combined with an over-the-top Internet-based home phone, commonly referred to as a VoIP service. VoIP services work with just about any Internet connection.

Household voice connections by the numbers:

- 76% of adults live in wireless-only households
- 79% of all fixed home voice connections are VoIP
- 5% of households in the United States have a legacy copper phone service, with many also having an active mobile service

To ensure that every American can benefit from enhanced service offerings made possible by network modernization, the FCC cut the red tape that prevented providers from upgrading their networks by replacing aging copper lines with modern infrastructure.

These network upgrades, often called technology transitions, occur when carriers shut down an old service or technology to provide a newer one. The FCC is easing burdens on providers and preempting state and local requirements that slow down this important transition.

While we build for the future, we are also focused on preserving consumer protections and access to critical emergency services.

Consumers will continue to receive:

- **Customer notifications:** When a company decides to completely discontinue a service, it must notify its customers and get FCC permission before turning off the service. When a telephone company simply stops offering an older voice service to new customers, existing customers will continue to receive that service until they no longer want it, and the telephone company will tell those customers that the service is being grandfathered.

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Learn more about what to do if you receive a notice at fcc.gov/notice.

- Access to 911 services: In many cases, upgraded networks will facilitate advanced 911 services that allow location information and pictures or video to be shared with first responders.

- Adequate replacement services (or alternative service options): Before a provider can request permission from the FCC to discontinue a service, they must ensure that adequate replacement voice services are available in any area where the primary provider is discontinuing copper voice services. This may be a cable company's home phone service or a 4G or 5G mobile service.

Currently, over 99.4% of homes and small businesses have access to 4G or 5G mobile services, and over 97% of homes and small businesses can immediately upgrade to a modern fixed Internet-based communications service.

Other changes to Commission rules will be largely invisible to consumers. They pave the way for improvements and more advanced connections between providers at the network level. These changes will not impact consumers' current service offerings or delivery.

Learn more by visiting, FCC.gov/tech-transitions.

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